

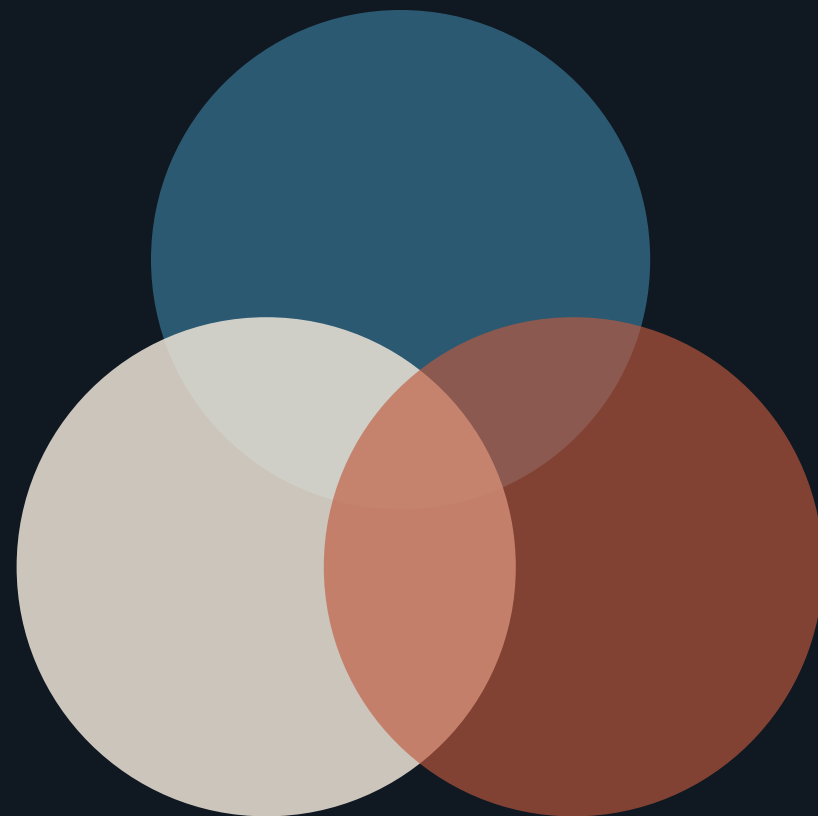
AI IN SPECULATIVE MEDIA AND LITERATURES · WEEK 2

What a Maker Owes

Mary Shelley, Frankenstein — the 1818 text

Volumes I–III · the 1831 Introduction · Brantlinger, “The Reading Monster”

Norton Critical Edition, 3rd ed. (ed. J. Paul Hunter, 2021)



This is a lot for the second week

Read for the shape

1

You are not expected to have absorbed every sentence. Get the architecture: who is speaking, to whom, and in what order the story is being handed along. We slow down together in class, on passages, not on plot.

Start early, read in long sittings

2

The novel punishes fifteen-minute sessions. The creature's narrative in Volume II is a single sustained voice and it works on you cumulatively — read that stretch in one go if you can manage nothing else.

Mark, don't summarise

3

Put a line in the margin anywhere someone explains why they did something. Those self-justifications are the novel's real subject, and they are what we will read closely.

Write before we begin

Think of something that was made and then left — a project abandoned mid-way, a pet taken on and given up, an account or a character or a model someone built and walked away from, a person who was brought into a situation and then not looked after.

What did the maker owe it? Write the obligation as a specific sentence, not a feeling.

Keep the page. We return to it in the last few minutes, and by then you will have the content of Shelley to argue with.

● KEY QUESTION FOR THE WEEK

What does a maker owe what they have made?

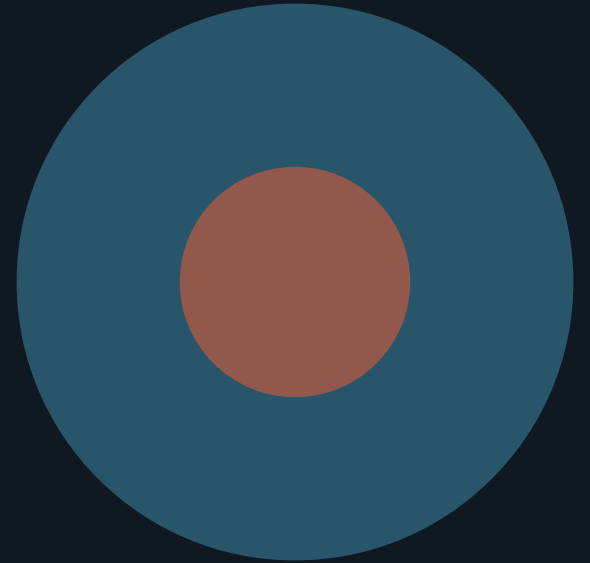
Everything today is an attempt on this question. Note that it is not “should we have made it” and not “is it conscious.” Those are the questions the novel is usually reduced to, and they are the two it is least interested in.

MOVEMENT ONE

The making and the leaving

Volume I, chapters I–VII · 0:20–1:08

Two years of labour. One night of attention.



Which Frankenstein are we reading?

1818 — our text

- Published anonymously in three volumes; Shelley was twenty.
- Elizabeth is Victor's first cousin — a member of the family he later fails.
- Victor's choices read as choices. Blame sits with him.
- Numbered by volume: Vol I ch. I–VII, Vol II ch. I–IX, Vol III ch. I–VII.

1831 — the version most people have met

- Heavily revised by Shelley thirteen years later, after Percy's death and three of her children's.
- Elizabeth becomes an unrelated foundling — the family is less implicated.
- Destiny and fate are added throughout, softening Victor's responsibility.
- Renumbered as chapters 1–24; our Vol I ch. I becomes two chapters.

Why the choice of text is itself an argument

The 1831 Victor is more swept along; the 1818 Victor decides. Since our question is what a maker owes, an edition that spreads the blame onto fate would change the answer. Keep this in mind on Thursday: the 1831 Introduction we will read was written to frame the softened version, not this one.

Three narrators, one inside the other

Walton

Letters and “in continuation”

Victor

Vol I – Vol III

The creature

Vol II, ch. III–IX

Safie's story

Vol II, ch. VI

Everything is hearsay

Walton writes to his sister in England. Victor tells Walton. The creature tells Victor. Safie's history reaches us fourth-hand. No voice in this book is unmediated.

The creature never speaks to us directly

His entire self-account is quoted by the man who abandoned him, to a stranger, months later, while dying. Everything he says has passed through Victor.

And yet it survives the transmission

The remarkable fact is how sympathetic the creature remains despite a hostile narrator. Ask what that tells us about Shelley's control of the frame.

What actually happens, and how little of it is the making

ch. I–II

Family, and a boy's reading

Geneva; Elizabeth; Clerval. Victor discovers Agrippa, Paracelsus, Albertus Magnus, and is mocked for it.

ch. III

Ingolstadt

Krempe humiliates the old learning; Waldman redeems modern chemistry. Victor is set alight by a lecture.

ch. IV

Two years in the charnel houses

The study of decay. The discovery of the principle of life is given a single sentence and no explanation.

ch. V

The night, and the flight

The creature opens his eyes. Victor runs, walks the streets till dawn, falls ill for months while Clerval nurses him.

ch. VI–VII

The cost lands on others

Recovery; Elizabeth's letter; William is killed; Victor sees the creature in the storm and says nothing; Justine is tried and executed.

Count the pages: the creation occupies a fraction of a volume. The consequences occupy the book.

The making takes two paragraphs

What Shelley refuses to tell us

- No mechanism. There is no machine, no lightning bolt, no laboratory apparatus described. Those are the films.
- No procedure. Victor says he discovered the cause of life and then explicitly declines to explain how, addressing Walton to justify the refusal.
- No moment. The animation itself gets a few clauses. The eye opens, the limb convulses, and the sentence is over.
- What we get instead is nine months of graveyards, dissecting rooms, sleeplessness and neglected letters home.

Withholding is a choice, not a gap

Shelley could have invented a procedure; her contemporaries did. Refusing one keeps the reader's attention on the maker rather than the method — and makes the novel immune to becoming dated.

The labour is moral, not technical

What Victor reports is not difficulty of engineering but corrosion of character: he stops writing to his father, stops seeing Clerval, stops noticing the seasons.

Question

If you cannot say how the thing was built, what is left to hold the maker accountable for? Shelley's answer is: everything that happened before and everything that happened after.

The first act after creation is flight

“It was on a dreary night of November”

Vol I, ch. V, opening sentence — the most quoted line in the book, and worth noticing that it is a weather report.

The comparison to hold

Two years of preparation. Roughly two minutes of attention.

Victor is meticulous about the specification and absent at deployment. He optimised entirely for the moment of success and made no provision whatsoever for the day after it.

The eye opens

1

The animation is over in a clause. Victor’s response is immediate and physical: the beauty he had selected turns, in his description, to horror. Nothing has happened except that the thing moved.

He leaves the room

2

He does not examine it, speak to it, or feed it. He goes to his bedchamber and tries to sleep. This is the hinge of the entire novel and it takes half a page.

It comes to him

3

The creature draws back the bed-curtain and, by Victor’s own account, makes sounds and reaches out a hand. Victor runs. Read that gesture again — the first thing the creature ever does is reach for him.

Months of illness, no search

4

Clerval arrives; Victor collapses into a nervous fever until the following spring. In all that time nobody looks for what he made. It has been outdoors, alone, for a season.

Victor's alibis — a catalogue

Aesthetic

He was repelled by how it looked. This is offered as sufficient explanation and never examined. It is also the only reason he gives on the night itself.

Medical

He was ill. The fever is real, but it begins after the flight, and it conveniently occupies the months in which a search would have been possible.

Epistemic

He could not have known. But he selected the features himself, over two years, and the novel shows him choosing scale deliberately for ease of work.

Reputational

He cannot speak at Justine's trial because he would not be believed, and would be thought mad. Notice that the cost of silence falls entirely on her.

Fatalistic

He describes himself as driven, seized, destined. Watch for this vocabulary — it is much heavier in the 1831 text, which tells you Shelley knew what it was doing.

Sentimental

He grieves loudly and at length. Grief performs moral seriousness while requiring nothing of him. It is his most effective alibi and the hardest to attack.

Every one of these is a reason for not looking. None of them is a reason for not providing.

Justine, and what silence costs other people

William is killed. Victor, arriving in the storm outside Geneva, sees the creature by lightning-flash and knows instantly who did it. Justine Moritz — a servant taken into the Frankenstein household, dependent on their protection — is charged, confesses under pressure from a confessor, and is executed. Victor attends. Victor says nothing.

The first innocent

The creature kills William. Victor kills Justine, by omission, in a courtroom, in public, with a full opportunity to speak.

Class and dependency

Justine has no standing. The household that raised her is the household that lets her hang. Shelley is precise about who absorbs the consequences of a gentleman's private catastrophe.

The pattern for the rest

From here on, everyone destroyed by the creature is destroyed because Victor will not disclose. The novel's body count is a function of concealment, not of monstrosity.

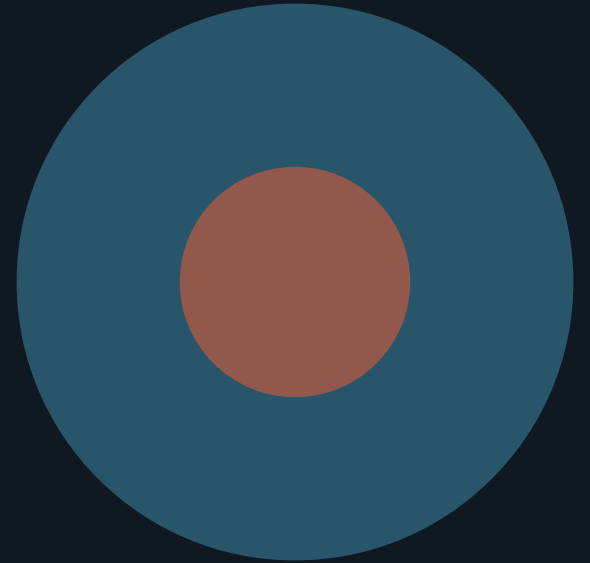
The harms in this novel are almost never caused by the created thing acting alone. They are caused by a maker who will not disclose what he made.

MOVEMENT TWO

The wall

Volume II, chapters I–IX · 1:18–1:54

He learns to speak from people who will not look at him.



The one place in the novel where the created thing speaks

ch. I–II

The sea of ice

Victor goes to Chamounix to feel better. The creature finds him on the glacier and asks to be heard. Astonishingly, Victor agrees.

ch. III

Before language

Confused sensation: light, cold, hunger. He discovers fire and burns himself on it. He is driven from a village by stones.

ch. IV–V

The hovel and the chink

He shelters against the De Lacey cottage and watches through a crack. Safie arrives; the family teaches her their language; he learns alongside her, unseen.

ch. VI–VII

The corpus

Safie's history. Then a lost portmanteau: Paradise Lost, Plutarch's Lives, Werter. And, in the pocket of the coat he took, Victor's journal of his own creation.

ch. VIII–IX

The approach and the demand

He speaks to the blind father and nearly succeeds. Felix returns and beats him out. He burns the cottage, travels to Geneva, kills William, frames Justine — and then asks Victor for a companion.

Note the order of events in the last row. He commits the murder before he makes the request — and he tells Victor so, himself.

The demand to be heard

“I ought to be thy Adam, but I am rather the fallen angel”

Vol II, ch. II. He is quoting the framework his reading gave him, and using it to file a complaint.

Why the Milton matters

Adam is made, placed in a garden, given a companion and spoken to daily by his maker. Satan is made and cast out. The creature has read both and worked out which one describes him. His grievance is not that he exists — it is that he was made under the first contract and delivered into the second.

He argues in the register of rights

Not mercy, not pity — obligation. He tells Victor what a creator owes, and grounds it in the relation itself rather than in his own goodness.

He concedes the murder is coming

His case is not that he is harmless. It is that his conduct followed from his treatment, and that the duty was breached first.

Victor listens

For once. It is the only extended act of attention Victor performs in the whole novel, and he abandons it the moment the story ends.

The training setup

INSIDE THE COTTAGE

Old De Lacey — blind
Felix · Agatha · Safie

A family in exile and poverty, teaching a newcomer their language out loud, every day, from a book.

the chink

IN THE HOVEL

The creature — unseen

A lean-to built against the outside wall, low enough that he cannot stand up in it. He receives everything and transmits nothing. For most of a year they do not know he exists.

And at night, unseen and unthanked, he clears their snow and gathers their firewood. He is contributing to the household that will beat him.

The asymmetry is total: perfect access to their speech, zero presence in their world. He is inside the conversation and outside the community, and the wall is what makes both true at once.

How he actually learns — the procedure, step by step

1 Sound before sense

He hears speech for weeks as pure music — pleasant, meaningless. He works out that the sounds attach to things before he can attach any of them himself.

2 Words for objects

Fire, milk, bread, wood. He builds a vocabulary of the nameable by correlating utterance with event, repeatedly, without feedback.

3 Words for relations

Father, sister, son. Harder, because they name nothing visible. He notes that he was a long time working these out — and they are the ones that apply to him.

4 A curriculum arrives

Safie needs teaching, so the family teaches out loud and from a book. He is not the intended student. He gets a full education as a side effect of someone else's.

5 Reading

Once Safie is taught to read, he learns to read. Written language is the point at which he stops depending on being within earshot.

6 Self-description

Only then does he have the equipment to state what has happened to him — and Volume II exists because he acquired it.

Nobody taught him. He was in range of teaching aimed at someone else, and he was patient.

The corpus — five texts and what each one does to him

Volney, Ruins of Empires

The book Felix reads aloud to teach Safie. Gives him world history, and with it the categories of conquest, property and race — he learns what humans do to each other before he meets any.

Paradise Lost

He reads it as true history. It supplies him with the only two available identities for a made being: cherished first creation, or outcast. He tests himself against both and finds he fits neither cleanly.

Plutarch's Lives

Public virtue, republics, great men. It gives him an ideal of the honourable life and a standard of admiration — and no explanation of how someone might enter such a life.

Sorrows of Werter

Interiority, sentiment, despair, suicide as a considered option. It teaches him to have feelings about his feelings. It also models self-destruction as a response to exclusion.

Victor's laboratory journal

Found in the pocket of the coat he took from the workshop. The record of his own assembly, in his maker's hand, including the disgust. He reads the account of his own creation as literature.

He chose none of them. Four arrived in a portmanteau dropped in a wood; the fifth he took by accident from the room he was made in. His entire moral vocabulary is a function of someone else's luggage.

Trained on a corpus, then despised for what you became

The claim

The creature learns language by eavesdropping through a wall on a family that will reject him on sight. He is, among other things, the most vivid account we have of what it might feel like to be trained on a corpus and then despised for what you became.

Keep the analogy honest

The strongest version of this comparison is not a claim about machine experience. It is a claim about makers: that a system's behaviour is substantially a function of what it was given and how it was received, and that blaming the artefact for that is a way of not being accountable for it. That argument survives even if the creature's inner life has no counterpart at all.

What holds

Acquisition without instruction. A corpus he did not select. Fluency achieved before any social standing. Competence read as threat rather than as achievement.

What does not

He wants things. He suffers. He has one body, one history, and a continuous life. Nothing in this course should be described as feeling what he feels on the strength of an analogy.

The transferable part

Not the interiority — the structure. Somebody assembles a thing from materials they chose, releases it, and then treats its outputs as evidence of its nature rather than of their choices.

The plan, and why it fails

1

He plans for months

He rehearses the conversation. He waits for the season, for a day when the others are out. He has thought about this more carefully than Victor thought about anything.

2

He chooses the blind man

This is the sharpest thing in the novel. He has correctly identified that his only chance is with the one person who cannot see him — he knows exactly what the problem is.

3

It is working

Old De Lacey hears him out, finds him eloquent, and is moved. On the evidence of language alone, the creature is welcome. The scene is, for about a page, going well.

4

The others return

Agatha faints, Safie flees, Felix beats him with a stick. Nobody asks a question. The verbal case is annihilated by two seconds of visual evidence.

The lesson he draws

That there is no version of himself that can be admitted. Not a better argument, not more patience, not more service rendered in secret. The barrier is not what he says; it is that he is seen saying it.

He burns the cottage that night. Then he sets out for Geneva to find his maker — and on the way, he meets a child who turns out to bear Victor's name.

Ask the room: is the burning of the cottage the first act you cannot defend? Or is it still defensible, and the murder is the line? Make them say where their line is and why.

The corpus question

- 1 The creature's morality comes from four books he found in a bag. Does that make his values less his own? Give a criterion, not an intuition — what would have to be true for a value to count as yours?
- 2 Old De Lacey is persuaded and Felix is not. Both encounter the same being. What exactly does sight add that changes the verdict, and is there anything in the novel that could have overcome it?
- 3 He does all the work of self-education and gets none of the credit for it. Where else have you seen competence treated as evidence of danger rather than of worth?

Four minutes each. Then three pairs report — one sentence, one chapter reference.

The demand — and it is a contract

He asks for one thing: a companion of his own kind, as deformed as he is, made by the same hands. In exchange he offers to leave Europe entirely, live in the wilds of South America, eat no meat, and never be seen by a human being again. Victor initially agrees.

It is modest

He does not ask for freedom, acceptance, restitution, or a place among people. He asks for one other being and permanent exile. It is the smallest request the situation permits.

It is conditional and stated

He names the consideration on both sides and the penalty for breach. This is the only agreement in the novel where the terms are made explicit by either party.

It is an argument about obligation

The request only makes sense if Victor owes him something. The creature has spent Volume II establishing exactly that, in order to arrive here.

And it is made by a murderer

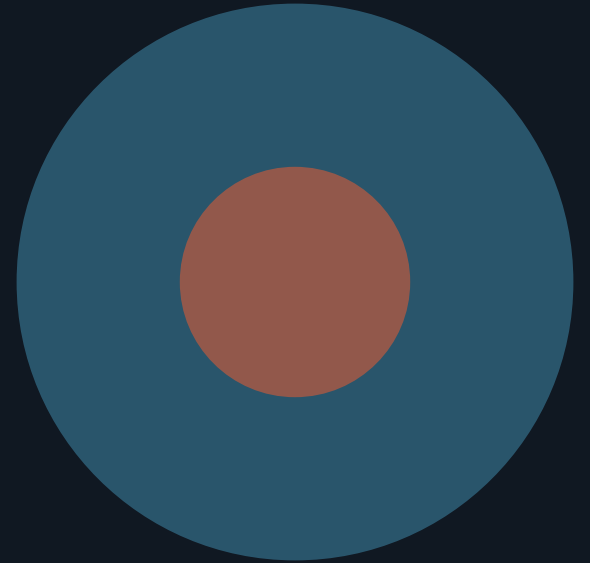
He has just described killing a child and planting evidence on a servant. Shelley refuses to let the appeal be clean, and refuses to let the guilt cancel the claim.

MOVEMENT THREE

The promise, and the breaking of it

Volume III, chapters I–VII and Walton in continuation · 1:54–2:18

Victor performs the only act of foresight in the book — and it is a betrayal.



The consequences arrive in order

ch. I–II

Delay

Victor travels to England with Clerval, sightseeing, putting off the work he has promised. Months pass.

ch. III

The Orkneys

In a hut on a remote island he nearly finishes the female — then tears her apart while the creature watches through the window. The threat follows.

ch. IV–V

Clerval

He sinks the remains at sea, drifts to Ireland, and is arrested for a murder committed while he was on the water. The victim is his oldest friend.

ch. VI

The wedding night

He marries Elizabeth, sends her to their room alone, and patrols the house with a pistol looking for an attacker who was never coming for him.

ch. VII · Walton

The pursuit reverses

His father dies. Victor becomes the hunter and is led north across the ice by a quarry that leaves him food. He dies on Walton's ship; the creature comes aboard to speak over his body.

Everyone who dies in this volume dies because Victor will not say what he knows to a single other person.

Why he destroys her — read the reasons exactly

Victor's four reasons, in his own order

- She might refuse the bargain — she was not party to it.
- She might find him repulsive and turn to human company instead.
- She might be worse than he is — malignant by her own nature.
- They might have children, and a race of them could threaten humanity.

Victor's reasons good ones? If you find yourself agreeing with him about the risk, notice that you have just agreed that a being should be destroyed for what she might choose.

Reason one is a moral insight

He has recognised that the second creature would be a person with her own will, who could not be bound by a contract made about her. This is correct, and it is the only time he thinks this way.

And he uses it to justify killing her

The recognition of her autonomy is deployed as grounds for destruction rather than as grounds for asking her. He grants her personhood exactly far enough to make her dangerous.

He does it in front of him

The creature is at the window. Victor sees him there and tears the work apart anyway. This is not a private decision quietly taken; it is a demonstration.

The most consequential misreading in the novel

“I will be with you on your wedding-night”

Vol III, ch. III — spoken as Victor destroys the female.

What Victor hears

A threat against himself. He arms himself, marries Elizabeth anyway, and on the night sends her to the bedroom alone so that he can search the house for his own assassin.

What was said

A promise of symmetry. Victor destroyed the creature’s companion on the eve of her existence; the creature will destroy Victor’s on the night of the wedding. The sentence is not ambiguous. It is only ambiguous to a man who cannot conceive that anyone else’s loss matters as much as his own.

Why this belongs in this course

Victor has all the information. The message is in plain language, delivered directly, with the reasoning attached. He still gets it wrong — because he cannot model the other party as having interests structured like his own.

Every failure in this novel is a failure of interpretation by the maker, not a failure of communication by the made.

The last word, and who gets to give it

The pursuit inverts

The creature leads Victor north across the ice, leaving marks and, on occasion, food. He keeps his maker alive in order to be chased by him. It is the closest thing to a relationship either of them achieves.

Victor dies unreformed

On the ship, dying, he warns Walton against ambition — and then, in nearly the same breath, tells him not to give up the voyage. He has learned the vocabulary of the lesson without the content.

The creature grieves

He is found over the body. He does not gloat. He gives an account of his own wretchedness, calls himself worse than his maker in his own estimation, and announces he will destroy himself.

Walton believes him

The frame closes with the only human who ever heard the creature out without a prior grievance — and Walton, who has spent the novel wanting glory, lets him go and turns the ship for home.

Nobody watches him die. Shelley ends the book with the creature carried away on an ice raft, into darkness and distance — unwitnessed to the last.

Shelley, Frankenstein (1818), Walton, in continuation.

MOVEMENT FOUR

The maker's own account

The 1831 Introduction · Brantlinger, "The Reading Monster" · 2:26–3:00

One more frame around the frame — and this one is Shelley's.



Shelley on how she made it

The occasion

Written thirteen years later, for a cheap reprint series, to explain how a young woman came to think of so hideous an idea. She is answering a question she has clearly been asked too often.

What the framing does

The idea arrives rather than being had. She is a listener at the edge of a conversation among men, receiving something she did not construct. The parallel to a creature at a wall is not subtle, and it is not an accident.

The scene she stages

Villa Diodati, summer 1816. Byron, Percy, Polidori, the ghost-story competition, the rain. Overheard talk about galvanism and the principle of life. Then a waking dream, at night, unbidden.

“My hideous progeny”

Her own phrase for the book, in her farewell to it. The author adopts Victor’s vocabulary for her creation — and unlike him, sends it out into the world with an affectionate blessing.

Read it as a document with a job to do, not as evidence. It is a retrospective account by an author with reasons — and it introduces the softened 1831 text, not the one you have been reading.

Patrick Brantlinger, “The Reading Monster”

The argument, in brief

Brantlinger reads the creature as a figure for the newly literate reader of the early nineteenth century — self-taught, formed by whatever books came to hand, and alarming to the educated classes precisely because of that literacy. On this reading, what makes him monstrous to the De Laceys is not only his body: it is that he has acquired their culture without their permission and without their institutions.

Discussion

Brantlinger’s anxious elite feared a reading public they could not supervise, formed by cheap print they did not select. Ask students to name the present-day version of that fear without letting them settle for the easy answer — and to say who, in the current version, is cast as the De Laceys.

Why this essay and not another

The Norton’s eleven essays lean toward science, gender, ecology and race. This one is about reading — about a mind assembled from a corpus.

What to test it against

Volume II, chapters V–VII. Whether the essay’s account of self-education matches what the novel actually shows, and where it has to leave something out?

Related materials

Elizabeth Young on Black Frankenstein and Anne Mellor on racial science, both in the same section — they take up how the reception of a made body gets racialised.

Build the case

1 Prosecution

Make the case that Victor's decisive wrong is the abandonment in Vol I, ch. V, not the creation in ch. IV. Cite two passages.

2 Defence

Make the strongest possible case for the Orkney decision (Vol III, ch. III) on its own terms. You must engage the fact that she was never asked.

3 The corpus

Using Vol II, ch. V–VII and Brantlinger, argue whether the creature's values are his own. State your criterion first.

4 The frame

Everything the creature says reaches us through Victor. Argue whether that makes his testimony more or less credible, and why Shelley built it that way.

What the novel actually answers

What does a maker owe what they have made?

1

Continued attention

Not affection, and not approval. The novel's minimum is that you keep looking at it. Victor's first and worst act is leaving the room — everything after is elaboration.

2

Disclosure to third parties

The obligation is not only to the creature. Justine, William, Clerval and Elizabeth all die because Victor will not tell anyone what exists. What you make becomes other people's risk, and they are owed the knowledge.

3

Keeping the terms you set

The only explicit agreement in the book is repudiated unilaterally, without notice, in front of the other party. Whatever else is owed, a maker who states terms is bound by them.

None of the three requires the created thing to be conscious, sympathetic, or even safe. They are obligations that attach to the act of making, and they survive every objection students will raise about what the creature is.

One paragraph

Take out the sentence you wrote in the beginning about what a maker owed something they left. Rewrite it now, using one specific passage from *Frankenstein* as either your evidence or your counter-example — and say what changed.

Optional Reading and Task

- Villiers de l'Isle-Adam, *Tomorrow's Eve* — selections: the android as designed replacement
- Čapek, R.U.R. — the made thing acquires numbers, and then a politics
- Bring one paragraph of text generated by a system you use, and be ready to say what corpus it came from